



Fibromyalgia



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Frustrating, Mind Numbing and Exhausting: My Fibromyalgia Experience

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My story of being diagnosed with Fibromyalgia, just after having early osteophytes in the neck.

Three years of debilitating spinal pain. More than 140 physiotherapy sessions. Orthopedic doctors. Physiotherapists. Ayurvedic doctors. Homeopaths. A mystery condition of fibromyalgia. That's how the three years of chronic pain and Covid-19 have been personally. As I start reflecting back on my journey, I feel such a sense of relief, deep gratitude, and a belief to turn around this.

It was October 2020 when my elder sister noticed swellings in my right arm. I casually retorted about being in pain for 10 days. She immediately coerced me to see an orthopedic doctor. The doctor was a senior one in the city with over two decades of experience in Delhi's tertiary public hospitals. He prescribed muscle relaxants, multiple X-rays, MRIs, and basic cervical exercises. However, even after four weeks of being with him, my condition wasn't improving, the pain was making me bedridden and I was unable to perform my daily activities. I would wake up with

extreme pain in my neck and sleep with the same intensity of pain. I started looking for other orthopedics and physiotherapists.

Another orthopedic suggested I undergo blood tests, but all normal! Gradually the pain spread to my shoulders, Now I was unable to brush my teeth, stopped reading books, and stopped gardening (which I loved!). Simple tasks like taking a shower and wearing clothes seemed like monumental challenges. I would just crumble onto my bed at 5 as soon as work finished and only get up the next morning, agonizing in deep pain. It was for months I would be in bed for almost 16 hours a day. All this was just after months of the devastating Covid-19 lockdown and intensive relief work. My loved ones started getting worried and were waiting to understand what was happening, but the MRIs did not show a thing.

I changed doctors and eventually got into a 15 physio-session package in a posh south Delhi center at Rs. 1700 per session. Unable to find answers and clarity, I was inclined toward stopping the treatment. I went to another doctor, another physio. A 30-session package now, with a guarantee of pain relief. Meanwhile, I got another MRI of my cervical. It showed there was osteophyte generation in the neck and slight degeneration, the condition was worsening. The doctors said at the age of 29, I was too young for this. However, my intensity of pain was too severe for the MRI reports. I continued my physio sessions. My life was getting affected, I was unable to travel on the road because of bumps, and sitting and standing for too long became impossible. I would go to work and had to lie down on a mattress after every 2 hours. There were crackling noises from my elbows and shoulders. The pain now was spreading to the neck, back, and even arms. I started wearing a hand support and then a neck collar. I stopped traveling even in the metro as standing up for 20 minutes was horrifying. My friends started visiting me at home, I thought I would lose my loved ones. How do I make people understand what was happening to my body? If my doctors weren't taking me seriously, how can others do so? I started getting tired and emotionally drained.

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During this time, an experienced doctor and a physiotherapist who has been helping me informed me about a condition called fibromyalgia. It was a condition of widespread musculoskeletal pain, induced by physical causes and further exacerbated by psycho-social issues and grief. I was in the disability sector for half a decade but could not comprehend I might have an invisible disability which is difficult to diagnose in the first place.

I was forced to take breaks from my work. Consecutive 5 half days, 3 days leave, coming late to going early but nothing was working. Finally, in October 2022 I took a month's break from everything and moved out of the city. The plan was to come back to Delhi and do a 10-day Ayurvedic panchakarma treatment in a private setup. By this time, I was aware that my heart and soul had to have a buy-in for any treatment to work. Resistance from within will be counter-productive for any external treatment. The week-long break was my effort to prepare my mind and body for an alternative treatment.

I still live with the pain, it is very much a part of how I breathe, live, and thrive. As I write this in August 2023 it has been nearly 3 years living with the condition. Gradually, I realized the intimate relationship between emotions, grief, and physical pain. In March 2023 I resumed going to the gym and in July, on my birthday I tried to go swimming. I could not have endured, and would not have been here without the kindness I received. It has been a privilege. There are things that worked magically.

First, I got an abundance of love, support, and care from my friends, family, and colleagues. It is a privilege to be in a workspace that is as accommodating as they were and surrounded by loved ones. I was unable to explain what was happening with my body, but friends-family were as calm as they could be. I canceled plans to meet and prioritized other things often as my pain would flare up unannounced but they remained steadfast with me. They changed their world around for me and were changing mine too, for the good, one step at a time. My 8-year-old nephew gave me monumental life lessons about life and self-care.

Second, I finally learned to accept that I do have a long-term pain condition. For two years, I kept running from pillar to post in search of a cure for my pain. I just

wanted it to be over and live a 'normal' life. This is in spite of working with Children with Disabilities who have lifelong conditions, our major task cut out is to instill acceptance, and belief in parents but also share a bitter dose of reality. Certain conditions don't get cured, they get better and one has to learn to manage it. I could not practice what I was preaching. The pain would not go away, there was an invisible understood diagnosis that would remain there for a long time. I kept on searching for answers for 'why me' while the question was 'what now'. The acceptance is still beaming in gradually.

Third, I realized the importance of a break. My friends kept on pushing me for a break but I thought my work drives me and can't ever be a source of pain for me. I was so wrong, the intensive work, COVID relief, and the induced grief were taking a toll on me. My shoulders were caving in. While on a break, I was fortunate to meet some kind folks who started a massage-based treatment there only. My stay was extended from 5 days to 14. Change of place, meditation, a break from work, change of diet, 'nothingness', kindness of strangers, and an intensive non-invasive treatment started working. My pain would not go away, but after over three years it felt like healing was possible. There was also one more realisation, that healing and pain can coexist. I also started accepting my pain and working with it. One's body works for themselves, not against. There are still unanswered questions!

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.

